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Section A

Pre-reading activities

1 Look at the title of Text A. Work in groups and discuss what "a brighter future" means to you. The following are some hints for you to consider.

- Becoming a well-educated person
- Having a good career
- Having a happy family
- Being a useful person to society
- Contributing to the prosperity of the country

2 As a college student, what can you do to prepare yourself for a bright future? The following are some hints for you to consider.

- Work hard
- Keep an open mind
- Study for a larger purpose
- Develop a strong sense of responsibility
- Keep a balance between learning and having fun

Text A

1 Good afternoon! As president of the university, I am proud to welcome you to this university. Your achievement is the **triumph** of years of hard work, both of your own and of your parents and teachers. Here at the university, we **pledge** to make your educational experience as rewarding as possible.

2 In welcoming you to the university, I am reminded of my own high school graduation and the photograph my mom took of my dad and me. "**Pose** naturally," Mom instructed us. "Wait!" said Dad. "Let's take a picture of me handing him an alarm clock." The clock woke me up every morning in college. It is still on my office desk.

3 Let me share with you something that you may not expect. You will miss your old **routines** and your parents' reminders to work hard and **attain** your best. You may have cried tears of joy to be finally finished with high school, and your parents may have cried tears of joy to be finally finished with doing your laundry! But know this: The future is built on the strong **foundation** of the past.

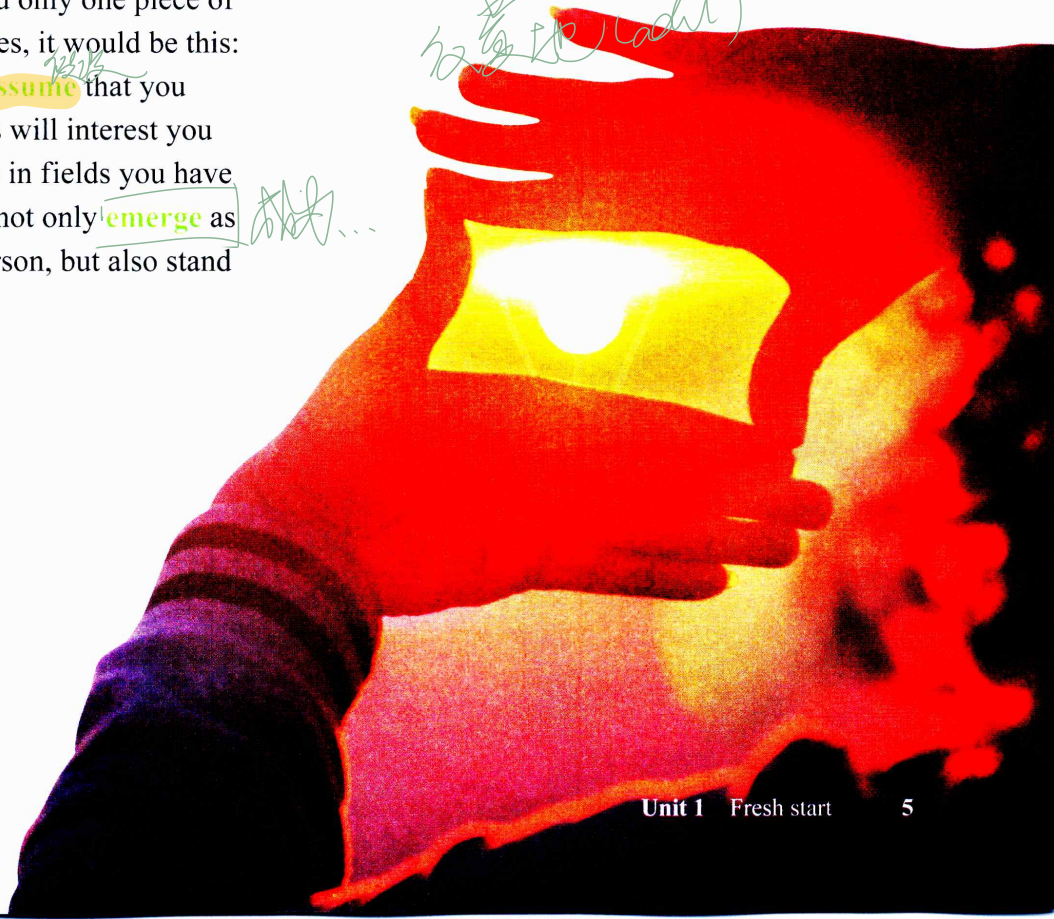
4 For you, these next four years will be a time unlike any other. Here you are surrounded by great **resources**: interesting students from all over the country, a learned and caring **faculty**, a **comprehensive** library, great sports **facilities**,

Toward a brighter future for all

and student organizations covering every possible interest – from the arts to science, to community service, and so on. You will have the freedom to explore and learn about new subjects. You will learn to get by on very little sleep, meet fascinating people, and pursue new passions. I want to encourage you to make the most of this unique experience, and to use your energy and enthusiasm to reap the benefits of this opportunity.

5 You may feel overwhelmed by the wealth of courses available to you. You will not be able to experience them all, but sample them widely! College offers many things to do and to learn, and each of them offers a different way to see the world. If I could give you only one piece of advice about selecting courses, it would be this: Challenge yourself! Don't assume that you know in advance what fields will interest you the most. Take some courses in fields you have never tried before. You will not only emerge as a more broadly-educated person, but also stand a better chance of discovering an unsuspected passion that will help to shape your future. A wonderful example of this is Leonardo da Vinci, who originally studied painting and sculpture. Over time, Leonardo da Vinci paired his studies in art with his love of science and nature, which made him a famous painter, sculptor, draftsman, engineer, scientist, and architect.

6 Here at the university, it may not always be pleasant to have so many new experiences all at once. In your dorm, the student next door may repeatedly play the one song, which gives you



a giant headache. You may be an early bird while your roommate is a night owl. And still, you and your roommate may become best friends. Don't worry if you become a little uncomfortable with some of your new experiences. I promise you that the happy experiences will outweigh the unpleasant ones. And I promise that virtually all of them will provide you with valuable lessons which will enrich your life. So, with a glow in your eyes and a song in your heart, step forward to meet these new experiences!

7 We have confidence that your journey toward self-discovery and your progress toward finding your own passion will yield more than personal advancement. We believe that as you become members of our community of scholars, you will soon come to recognize that with the abundant opportunities for self-enrichment provided by the university, there also come responsibilities. A wise man said: "Education is simply the soul of a society as it passes from one generation to another." You are the inheritors of the hard work of your families and the hard work of many countless others who came before you. They built and transmitted the knowledge you will need to succeed. Now it is your turn. What knowledge will you acquire? What passions will you discover? What will you do to build a strong and prosperous future for the generations that will come after you?

8 We take great pleasure in opening the door to this great step in your journey. We take delight in the many opportunities which you will find, and in the responsibilities that you will carry as citizens of your communities, your country, and the world. Welcome!

(*778 words*)

Culture notes

Leonardo da Vinci: Italian Renaissance artist, engineer, and scientist. His *Mona Lisa* is among the most popular and influential paintings of the Renaissance.

Section A

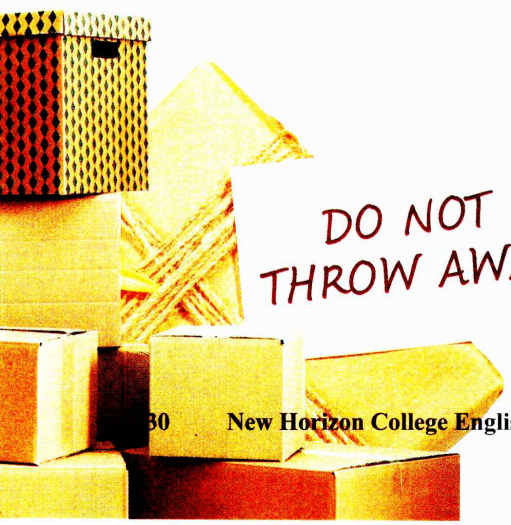
Pre-reading activities

1 How close are you to your parents? Check (✔) the statements which are true for you.

- ☐ 1 I often chat with my parents.
- ☐ 2 I have been missing my parents a lot since I left for college.
- ☐ 3 My parents and I remember each other's birthdays.
- ☐ 4 I never miss an opportunity to express my love to my parents.
- ☐ 5 My parents and I share some hobbies.
- ☐ 6 My parents encourage me to make my own decisions.
- ☐ 7 My parents always praise me for what I have achieved.
- ☐ 8 My parents and I share the traditional family values such as respect, harmony, honesty, and responsibility.

2 Work in pairs and discuss the following questions.

1 What advice would you give to those who want to be closer to their parents?
2 What traditional values do your parents hold? How have they influenced you with their words and deeds?



Text A

1 I watch her back her new truck out of the driveway. The vehicle is too large, too expensive. She'd refused to consider a practical car with good gas **efficiency** and easy to park. It's because of me, I think. She bought it to show me that she could.

2 "I'm 18," she'd told me so often that my teeth ached. "I am an adult!"

3 I thought, is that true? Just yesterday you watched some cartoons. What changed between yesterday and today?

4 Today she's gone, off to be an adult far away from me. I'm glad she's gone. It means she made it, and that I'm finally free of 18 years of responsibilities. And yet I wonder if she could take good care of herself.

5 She left a mess. Her bathroom is an **embarrassment** of damp towels, hair in the sink, and nearly empty **tubes** of **toothpaste**. I bring a box of big black garbage bags upstairs. Eye shadow, face cream, nail **polish** – all go into the trash. I **dump** drawers, sweep shelves clear, and clean the sink. When I am finished, it is as neat and impersonal as a hotel bathroom.

6 In her bedroom I find **mismatched** socks under her bed and purple **pants** on the **closet** floor. Desk drawers are filled with school papers, filed by year and subject. I catch myself reading through poems and essays, admiring high scores on tests, and reading her name, printed or typed neatly in the upper right-hand corner of each paper. I pack

A child's clutter awaits an adult's return



the desk contents into a box. Six months, I think. I will give her six months to collect her belongings, and then I will throw them all away. That is fair. Grown-ups pay for storage.

7 I have to pause at the books. Comic books, teen fiction, romantic novels, historical novels, and textbooks. Each book beloved. I want to be practical and stuff them in paper sacks for the used bookstore. But I love books as much as she does, so I stack them onto a single bookshelf to deal with later.

8 I go for her clothes. Dresses, sweaters, and shoes she hasn't worn since seventh grade are placed into garbage bags. I am a plague of locusts emptying the closet. Two piles grow to clumsy heights: one for charity, the other trash.

9 There are more shoes, stuffed animals, large and small posters, hair bands, and pink hair curlers. The job grows larger the longer I am at it. How can one girl collect so much in only 18 years?

10 I stuff the garbage bags until the plastic strains. I haul them down the stairs, two bags at a time. Donations to charity go into the trunk of my car; trash goes to the curb. I'm earning myself sweat and sore shoulders.

11 She left the bedroom a ridiculous mess, the comforter on the floor, the sheets tossed aside. I strip off the comforter, blanket, sheets, and pillows. Once she starts feeding coins into laundry machines, she'll appreciate the years of clean clothes I've provided for free.

Section A

Pre-reading activities

Work in pairs and discuss the following questions.

1 Who deserves to be called a hero? Why?

2 What qualities do you think make a hero?

- ☐ Bravery
- ☐ Dedication
- ☐ Selflessness
- ☐ A great sense of responsibility
- ☐ Loyal service to society and the country
- ☐ Other: _____

Text A

1 He was wandering in a rice field of dreams. The plants were taller than a man. Their ears hung full as brooms, and each grain was as big as a peanut. After walking a while he lay down in the leaf-shade, quite hidden. A rest was a good idea, because the wonder-plants went on and on.

2 Then Yuan Longping woke up, laughing. The rice plants, which he had tended for decades in Anjiang and then Changsha in Hunan Province, sowing and nurturing them, visiting daily on his motorbike to inspect them, were not quite there yet. But they still deserved their name of super rice. The leaves were straighter and taller than ordinary ones, and the grains plumper. They had all the vigor of the wild strain that he and his team had found in Hainan in 1970 and had crossbred with the domesticated variety. Some skeptical people told him he was wasting his time, since rice was a self-pollinator. He believed that crossbreeding was universal and that it always made the offspring stronger.

3 The figures spoke for themselves. With his new hybrid rice the annual yield was 20% higher. This meant that at least 70 million more people could be fed every year. China's rice yield had risen from 57 million tons in 1950 to 208 million in 2022,





TO FEED THE WORLD

transforming China from food deficiency to food security. Higher rice yields allowed farmers to turn more land to other uses – fruit, vegetables, fishponds – so that people not only had more to eat, but ate well. And this message was for China as well as the world. He traveled across Asia and to Africa and America to help people grow rice, as well as inviting his foreign peers to China to share his research. A fifth of all rice grown globally now comes from hybrids that were his.

4 For this Yuan Longping won the Medal of the Republic, China's highest state honor, and the World Food Prize. He was widely known as the Father of Hybrid Rice, and even an asteroid was named after him. Although he was famous, he chose to stay away from the spotlight and devoted himself to rice growing. His face was leathered by the sun and his big hands were rough from "playing in the mud" all day. He was far happier in his short-sleeved work shirts, out in his rice field, than in a suit in some conference hall. As an official of the World Food Prize Foundation said, Professor Yuan was incredibly humble. He never sought fame or adulation, but rather focused only on hard work and results that could help eradicate poverty and lift people out of hunger.

5 Yuan Longping was born in Beijing, but he enjoyed the countryside and the thought of growing tasty things. Inspired by his initial interest, he decided to study agriculture in college. After graduation, Yuan Longping took a job as a teacher in Anjiang Agricultural School. He said, "Having enough food was people's priority."



6 Yuan Longping had at first worked on **grafting**. He grafted **moonflowers** on sweet potatoes, tomatoes on potatoes, and a watermelon on a **pumpkin**, but found that any inherited **traits** vanished in the second generation. Then he read about plant **genetics**, and turned his full attention to China's **staple**, rice.

7 As a boy he was fascinated by the deliciousness of Xiaozhan Rice from Tianjin, said to be the best in China at that time. Around Anjiang, what the farmers wanted was quantity: **miracle**-yields from their fields. They would cross the mountains to get better seeds, so he did the same, traveling around China to find the strong wild male-**sterile** plants he needed. Once he found them, it took three years to perfect the **hybridizing** and another three to get his super rice into **commercial** production. Then, in a steep curve, yields **soared** away.

8 He kept on working to make rice better: salt-**tolerant** to grow by the coast, crossbred with corn to be more **nutritious**, enriched with vitamin A to improve people's eyesight. His mind was filled with the thought that if just half of the rice fields in the world were planted with his hybrid rice, an increase in yield of two tons per **hectare** would feed 400-500 million more people every year. And he still talked of plants taller than a man.

9 Outside the funeral home in Changsha on the day after his death, crowds came to lay a mountain of yellow and white **chrysanthemums**. Several of the **mourners** said that whenever they sat down to a meal, or merely smelled the fragrance of rice, they would remember "Grandfather Yuan". Among the flowers were the traditional bowls of boiled rice, the best thing to **commemorate** the Father of Hybrid Rice.

(*791 words*)

Culture notes

World Food Prize: an international award recognizing the achievements of individuals who have advanced human development by improving the quality, quantity, or availability of food in the world. Since 1987, the prize has been awarded annually and it is now administered by the World Food Prize Foundation.